

MARY I ►

The eldest daughter of Henry VIII, Mary I (reigned 1553–1558) married Spain's Catholic king, Philip II, and restored the Catholic faith in England. Her reign was marked by violence and bloodshed, and after ordering the execution of leading Protestants she became known as "Bloody Mary."



Coin depicting Mary I, commemorating her marriage to Philip II of Spain



▲ DEFEAT OF THE SPANISH ARMADA

In 1588, King Philip II of Spain sent a fleet of 130 ships—the Spanish Armada—to invade England and overthrow Elizabeth I. This was the biggest threat England had faced for centuries, yet the English fleet triumphed after just an eight-hour battle. This remarkable victory showcased the country's naval strength to the rest of Europe.

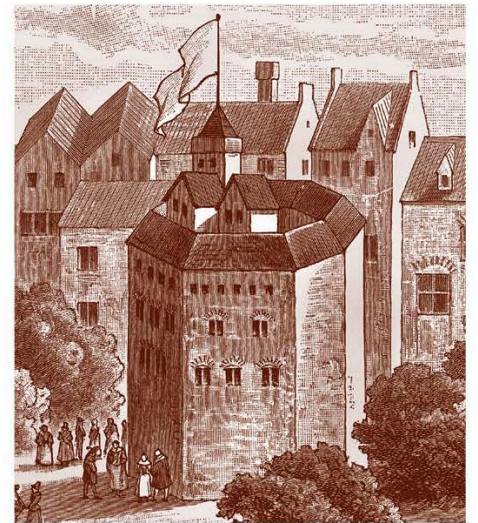
▼ ELIZABETH I

Dedicated and shrewd, Elizabeth I (reigned 1558–1603) established herself as a powerful monarch who was highly respected by her subjects. She reinstated Protestantism but was a much more tolerant ruler than her sister Mary. Her reign was considered a golden age in England. She never married, and without an heir to the throne, Elizabeth's death in 1603 marked the end of the Tudors.



WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE ►

Still widely agreed to be the greatest figure of English literature, William Shakespeare wrote almost 40 plays, including Hamlet, Macbeth, and Romeo and Juliet. Many were performed at the open-air Globe Theatre in London (right). It burned down in 1613, but was reconstructed in 1997 and still puts on performances today.



CHILD IN TIME

After King Henry VIII died in 1547, his only son Edward VI took to the throne at the age of nine. The "Boy King" suffered with ill health and died seven years later in 1553.

